Basic Accessibility Testing

In short

You don’t need to be an expert to check your site. Try using only your keyboard, and zoom to 200% to check text still fits on the screen. Then run a free scanner, but remember that it only finds about 30% of problems.

What is it for?

Testing makes sure that what gets built actually works for everyone. The goal is to never accidentally release a beautiful page that's completely broken for someone using a screen reader or a keyboard.

While automated tools are useful, they can't find everything. They only catch about 30% of accessibility errors. An automated tool can check if a picture has an image description (alt text), but it can't tell you if the description actually makes sense. You still have to use your own judgement to check the rest.

How to support it

You don't need to be an expert to test your site. Try these three quick checks right now.

- Use 'Tab' to move forward, 'Shift + Tab' to go back, 'Enter' or 'Space' to select, the arrow keys inside menus and radio buttons, and 'Escape' to close pop-ups. Check that you can reach every button without a mouse.
- Zoom your browser to 200% using 'Ctrl' or 'Cmd' and '+'. Ensure text doesn't overlap or vanish off the screen.
- Run a free scanner like Lighthouse or Axe DevTools in Chrome. It'll quickly point out basic bugs, like poor colour contrast.

Useful links

- World Wide Web Consortium (W3C) - Easy Checks (A first review of Web Accessibility)
- WebAIM - Testing with a Keyboard

Abbreviations

The full form of each abbreviation used in this document.

Cmd: Command

Ctrl: Control

W3C: World Wide Web Consortium